

[Return to Search](#)

The affairs of Daura

Author(S): Smith, M. G. (Michael Garfield)

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 46

Culture (OWC): [Hausa \(MS12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1958-1959

Coverage Date: 1800-1958

Place Coverage: Daura, Nigeria

Section Title(S)

Conditions of Slavery • Kinship at Daura

Throne slaves were important administrative and political agents in all Hausa and Fulani chiefdoms during the last century. However, to my knowledge, besides Fulani and Hausa Daura, only Hadeija allowed intermarriage between official slaves and the chief's kinswomen. At Zaria, Katsina, Kano, and Sokoto, the ruling Fulani refused to allow their kinswomen to marry slaves. Apparently at Daura such marriages between the dynasty and senior slave staff antedated the jihad. Thus by recognizing such marriages, the Kuninkawa Fulani who ruled western Daura after Malam Ishi'aka's death apparently adopted the practice of their Hausa predecessors.

[174
Historical
Reconstruction](#)

[567
Slavery](#)

[582
Regulation Of
Marriage](#)

Kinship at Daura

As remarked above, the Hausa of Daura stress agnatic descent and are organized in patrilineages of varying depth and extent. For the pagan Hausa or Maguzawa, patrilineages are also the primary units of social organization; but Maguzawa patrilineages are localized, exogamous, and differentiated [47](#) ritually by their relations with particular localities and spirits. Among Muslim Hausa and Fulani, lineages are neither exogamous nor localized, and cousin marriages are preferred. Following Islamic models, Fulani prefer to arrange marriages between brothers' children, while Muslim Hausa prefer cross-cousin marriages of either type. In both the Fulani and Hausa kinship systems, cross-cousins are joking relations whose relationship involves privileged familiarity. Accordingly, Fulani and Hausa rulers like to appoint cross-cousins to their staffs, thus converting these warm and solidary kinship relations to political use. Isolated by office, rank, and political interests from

[184
Cultural Participation](#)

[563
Ethnic Stratification](#)

[602
Kin Relationships](#)

[611
Rules Of Descent](#)

[614
Clans](#)

his agnates, slaves, and client officials and continuously obliged to guard against misinformation and intrigues, the Fulani or Hausa chief relies heavily on his cross-cousins for confidential information on such affairs within and beyond the palace and looks to them for frank advice on appropriate courses of action. In addition, the patterns of joking and privileged familiarity that link cross-cousins provide chiefs with appropriate opportunities for easy social relations, which they need and appreciate. With his kinsmen, with his wives, slaves, officials, and commoners, the chief should always be circumspect. Only with his cross-cousins may he freely relax; but precisely for this reason, cross-cousins appointed to office are favorably placed to mislead and betray their kinsman, the chief, if so inclined.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)